UNSUNG, UNBREAKABLE

India's campaign wasn't just about fight; it was also about form. This was a showcase of skill and adaptability across the board. There was Sundar, overlooked for much of the series with the ball, but invaluable with the bat, a true three-dimensional cricketer. There was Ravindra Jadeja, ever reliable, punching above his weight in both departments. And Akash Deep, all sinew and control, chipping in with crucial lower-order runs and bowling tireless spells. Yashasvi Jaiswal and Rahul were stoic at the top, navigating the Dukes ball under heavy clouds and pressure. Prasidh Krishna, briefly dropped, showed his nous by baiting set batters with seemingly innocuous lengths before pulling the rug from under their feet. Pant's scores (134, 118, 65 and 74) weren't just counter-attacks, they were statements.

India's six-run win in the final Test at The Oval was also its slimmest margin of victory ever in a Test

And then there was Siraj, the series' heartbeat. His stamina was matched only by his craft—cross-seam deliveries that jagged in or seamed away, subtle angle changes, and a motor that simply refused to stop. India, for once, weren't carried by a single messiah. This was a relay of heroes. Nearly a dozen different players stood up at different moments—a hallmark of healthy team dynamics. As Rahul, one of those heroes, put it after the final Test: "This is where the change begins. This Indian team will win a lot more outside India in coming years."

TESTED AND TEMPERED

In what finished as one of the best Test series of the 21st century, all five Test matches went down to the wire on the final day (the last time this happened was in the 2017-18 Ashes series in Australia). It wasn't just cricket, it was war, playing out one session at a time. And in that war, India proved they weren't just talented, they were tempered in steel.

That six-run margin at The Oval separated a drawn series from a historic defeat. But its ripple effect may be far greater. Because had India lost 3-1, the knives would have been out, questions would have been raised: was Gill too green to lead? Had India moved on too soon from Kohli and Rohit Sharma? Could the IPL generation handle Test cricket's grind?

But those knives have been sheathed, at least for now. A drawn series now feels like a triumph—because



Test Matches 85
Runs: 3,886
Avg: 37.72
Highest score: 175*

Wickets: 330
Avg: 25.16
Best bowling 7/42

RAVINDRA JADEJA 36

Left-handed batsman/ bowler

Ravindra Jadeja has long defied easy definition. Once caricatured for his flamboyance and nicknamed 'Sir Jadeja', he has transformed into one of Indian cricket's most valuable assets. At 36, he has completed perhaps his most defining series as a batting all-rounder—compiling 516 runs at an average of 86.00—the highest among all batsmen. Batting mostly at No.6 or lower, he scored either a half-century or century in four matches. His unbeaten 107 in Manchester was a masterclass—with India staring down the barrel, Jadeja's composure and craft salvaged a draw. Innings after innings, he shepherded the tail, absorbed pressure, offered lower-order muscle. With the ball, he claimed 7 wickets—modest returns by his standards—but his ability to hold up one end allowed India's pace attack to operate in shorter, more incisive bursts. In a summer of bold narratives, Sir Jadeja's mastery stitched India's campaign together. He didn't just contribute, he punched above his weight.

—Amitabh Srivastava